Newsletter: June 2026

Overview:

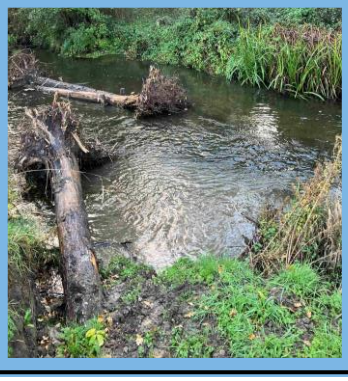
Hello River Champions! First of all, we'd like to apologise for the lack of recent updates and thank you for your patience. Alongside being stretched at work, our project lead James White has also been enjoying becoming a new dad after welcoming Penelope Rose to the world on April 1st (no this isn't an April Fools'!). But we're hoping to see a lot more activity in coming months for reasons you'll see in this newsletter!



Training Days: In March, we welcomed the Friends of Brookvale, Manor Farm Park and Sheldon Country Park, who have already started busying themselves with collecting data!

Packington Fisheries will soon be trained as the latest river champions. They already monitor their cherished River Blythe, and even help deliver works that promote habitat diversity by introducing valuable woody material.





Sewage outfalls project: We are monitoring sewage pollution in the River Cole and Sutton Park using high-frequency sensors. This will tell us the regularity of discharges, and our own river champions are helping support this. We will keep you informed on outputs from this later in the year.

Website updates: We apologise that our website is not showing all data logged – rest assured your inputs are being stored! IT should resolve this soon. If you haven't done so before, please do check out our website for lots of interesting trends and useful resources - https://birminghamriverchampions.shinyapps.io/bhamrc/.

Sampling update: We've now collected **237** Urban Riverfly and **175** water chemistry samples - over 400 valuable pieces of data are being analysed by students at the university to capture patterns in river health. This wealth of information is a testament to the dedication of all you river champions!

UNIVERSITY OF BIRMINGHAM

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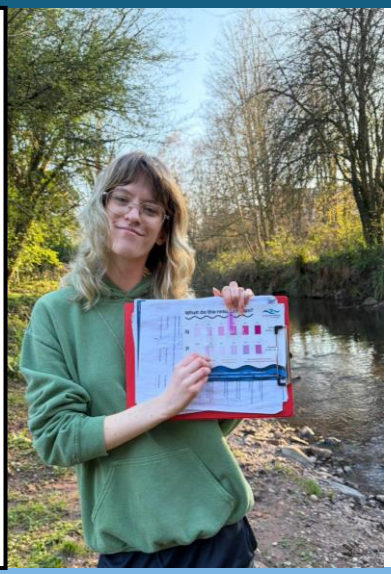
Follow us on social media!

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University student takeover:

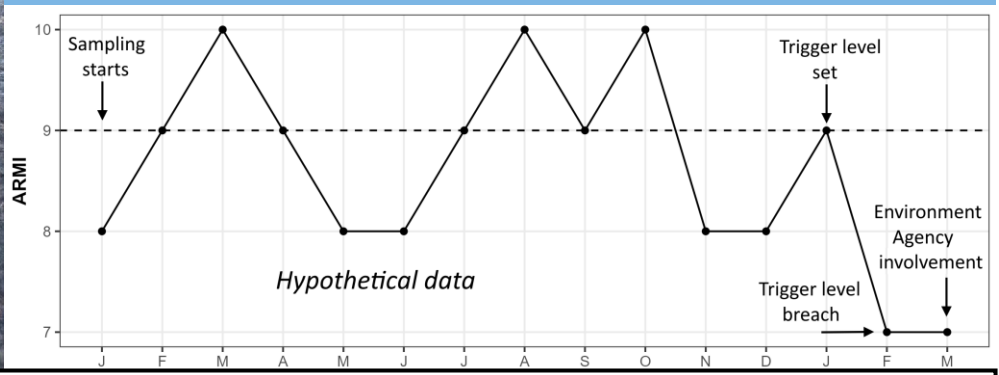
In recent months, 3rd-year student Ashleigh (left) has been supporting groups in the Rea catchment. Now 1st-year student Safina (right) will be doing the same in her summer placement, while also leading the student group after we said goodbye to recently graduated Asha – who we wish to thank for all his efforts.







'Trigger levels': The Environment Agency have set trigger levels at sites with consistently sampled data lasting over a year. This means that your Urban Riverfly data now has a threshold, where if ecological health scores drop below this twice consecutively the Environment Agency should investigate, even if *via* a desktop assessment – as depicted in this example:



New volunteer engagement officer: Some very exciting news is that we will be welcoming a new volunteer engagement officer to support the delivery of Birmingham River Champions later this summer. Their time will be split between our project and the newly established Rugby River Champions project, funded by Rugby Borough Council who want us to emulate our work there.

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